The Planned Partition:

Caste and Religion in a Divided Punjab, 1858-1947

AS Research Seminar Paper

Mr. Edmonds / Mr. Franz

May 22, 2026

All her eyes see is red. Before the rifles echo across the train tracks, mixtures of uncertainty and hope smear across the air of the excessively crowded train. Families get on board trains either full of Hindus and Sikhs or Muslims, making their journeys across the newly made borders. News had just spread that Hindus and Sikhs needed to live in India while Muslims needed to move to Pakistan, creating a sense of mass migration and panic. A mother and father grab onto their young daughter's hand tightly and board the train, disregarding their child's claustrophobia. Her small, innocent eyes are met with people fighting over who will get a seat, men sitting on the roof of the train, and the screams of women being pushed off. The fear in her eyes can be seen from miles away but all she can hope for is to not be stranded from the two people who mean the world to her. As the family manages to get a train cabin filled with countless other people, a sense of false hope fills their hearts. They have been on this train for hours now, in efforts to make it across the border safely, but it suddenly comes to a stop. The daughter asks her parents whether they made it to their new home but all she is met with is a loud, lingering silence.

This silence is broken abruptly with a mob of rifles, swords, and synchronized screams ringing across the train. Her eyes mirror reflections of women holding tight onto their children, men fighting off the mob of extremists, and rivers of blood trickling down the floors. She notices her mother breathing faster than normal with a pale face full of fear. Her mother quickly grabs onto her daughter's hands and pulls her underneath the seat. But how long can they hide for? A man approaches their cabin and all the daughter hears are screams so loud her ears felt like they could burst. All her eyes see is red. Prayers are mumbled in hopes for the man to not kill them the way those in the cabin were brutally murdered. Their efforts fail. The man bends down and

says words in a language not understood by the daughter. Just then, her eyes were shut tight and never opened again.

Though this is a fictionalized account of the tragedies that occurred during the 1947 train massacres, a series of trains that were attacked while trying to make their way across the borders, real life stories do not differ as much as one may think. Salima Hashmi, a survivor of a train massacre, illustrates "There were so many people on the roof of the train. They were from Rawalpindi trying to crossover to India. There was mayhem and crowds, and there was no light in the train compartment."[1] People were forced to move from everything they had known for their whole lives, get on a train, and make the journey to the newly separated countries based on religion. Some of those individuals, however, did not make it across the border as their fate decided otherwise. As much as it may seem these forms of violence in 1947 were instantaneous, they in fact resulted over an extended period of time throughout the British Rule. The British officially colonized India in 1858, following the Indian Rebellion of 1857. The rebellion was a joint force of Indians, regardless of religion, that joined together to attempt removing the British out of the country. The reason they joined together was due to rising anger against British expansion but mostly the fears of forced bounds to religious identities. Their efforts were not only met with failure, but with a change to their lives for centuries to come. The British began to slowly implement a "divide and rule" strategy to separate Indians by mostly religion and caste. This strategy deliberately exploited existing differences in regards to religion, caste, and social status which ultimately turned potential unity into internal conflict amongst Indians. This resulted in Indians turning against one another instead of coming together to overthrow the British, as they once did in 1857. This strategy's aftermath still exists today, continuing to drive

[1] Hashmi, Salima, "Oral history with Salima Hashmi, 2016 January 18", Stanford University Libraries, 2016 https://exhibits.stanford.edu/1947-partition/browse/interviews

the hate amongst Hindus and Muslims separated into India and Pakistan. Several wars between the two countries have resulted out of religious hate but how really did these countries get here? Following the Indian Rebellion of 1857, British officials in Punjab restructured their means of control through governmental policies to prevent unified resistance against the Crown. Through the classification of religious identity and caste, the British transformed Punjab's diverse population into increasingly rigid political communities. Over time, these divisions became competitive and hostile, ultimately contributing to the scale of the violence experienced in 1947.

The Indian Rebellion, or commonly referred as the Sepoy mutiny, of 1857 wrote the history of centuries to come. This rebellion can be thought as a mutiny amongst Indian soldiers, or sepoys, rising against the British but it was far more than that. Historian Peter Robb reflects " it is regarded not just as a mutiny in the Indian army and an uprising in regions of India but as an Indian revolt against the British. 'Indians rose against East India Company rule', according to one recent historian. It is said without reflection. The rebellion was thus a crucial stage and expression of two nations in making".[2] This perspective shifts the understanding of 1857 from a localized military revolt to something much broader and more significant. By framing it as a collective uprising against colonial rule, it highlights how individuals across different regions and backgrounds began to see themselves as part of a larger struggle. The idea that "Indians rose" suggests a level of shared purpose that went beyond individual grievances or isolated incidents. Differences in identity in regards to caste and religion has existed amongst Indians for a long period of time but it did not hinder them from recognizing the potential for losing their control to the British. As India contained a far greater variety of religious diversity than Britain,

[2] Robb, Peter, "On the Rebellion of 1857: A Brief History of an Idea", *Economic and Political Weekly,* Vol.42 No.19 (May 2007). https://www.jstor.org/stable/4419572?searchText=indian+rebellion+of+1857&searchUri=%2Faction%2FdoBasicSearch%3FQuery%3Dindian%2Brebellion%2Bof%2B1857%26so%3Drel&ab_segments=0%2Fbasic_search_gsv2%2Fcontrol&refreqid=fastly-default%3Af5f2bd278e0c595c2c95337f9c93615f&seq=2

the unity displayed during the rebellion demonstrated the possibility of collective resistance against the Crown. These social distinctions ultimately became a means of colonial control. At the same time, the reference to "two nations in making" points to how this unity would later come to be defined. Though Robb's argument seems to create common ground as to what the 1857 rebellion entailed, he lacks to address why this was such a crucial moment. This rebellion was an uprising against the British however it also set the ground for how the British would rule. The Indian sepoys who fought this rebellion were of diverse backgrounds who came together regardless of those differences but to prevent this from happening again, the British initiated their 'divide and rule' strategy to divide by identity and rule over the people. The social norms of having caste and religion as crucial points of identity that existed in India did not necessarily exist in such form in the west. This created a way for the British to ultimately control India by using these social norms to their advantage. The rebellion can be seen not only as a moment of resistance but also a turning point that shaped how both Indians and the British understood identity and power moving forward.

This rebellion revealed the possibility of unity, which was seen as a threat, among groups the British had viewed as separate. Hindu and Muslim soldiers, despite their differences, found themselves reacting to the same fears. Over time, the British broke this unity for their own advantage to divide and conquer. This was especially highlighted through the belief that British policies were interfering with their religious practices. An issue with greased cartridges, rifles rumored to be greased with cow or pig fat, had an uprising as many sepoys believed that "grease or fat is used in the composition of this cartridge paper"[3], a suspicion that had become so deeply

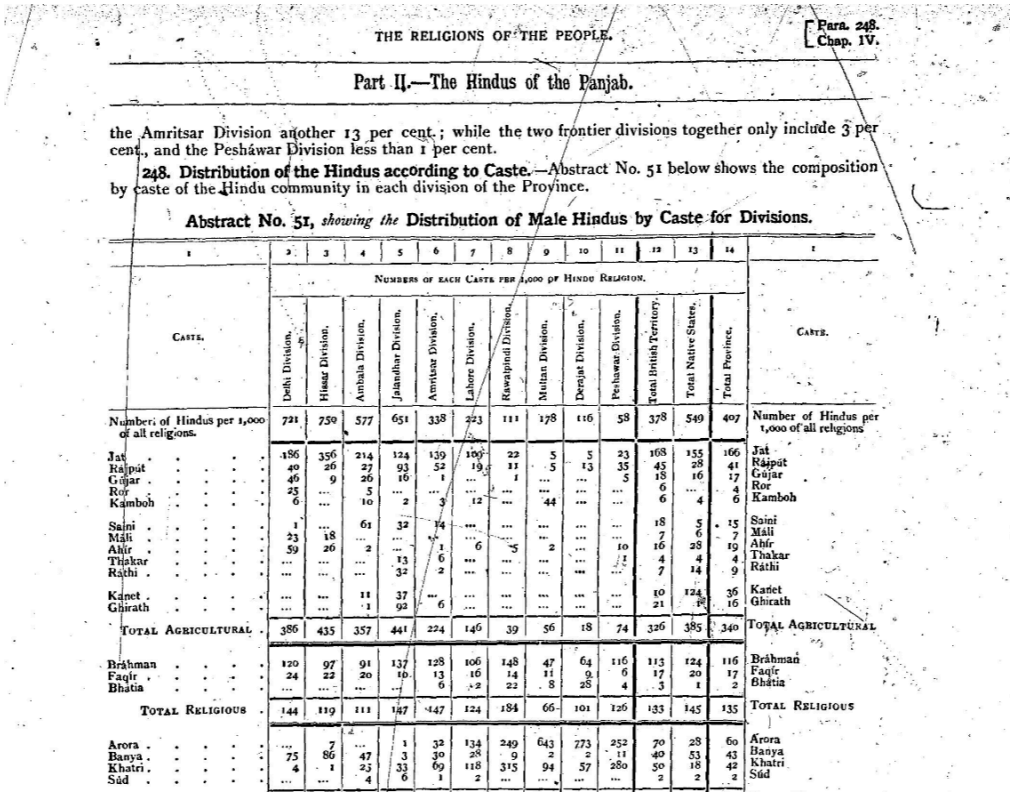
[3] Crawshay, Geo. "The Immediate Cause of The Indian Mutiny". Lecture at the Mechanic's Institution, Gateshead. London, England. November 4th, 1857. https://www.jstor.org/stable/60229514?searchText=indian+rebellion+of+1857&searchUri=%2Faction%2FdoBasicSearch%3FQuery%3Dindian%2Brebellion%2Bof%2B1857%26so%3Drel%26sd%3D1857%26ed%3D1860&ab_segments=0%2Fbasic_search_gsv2%2Fcontrol&refreqid=fastly-default%3Ac6e0f6a12c3e03b8a922e93729d67b30&seq=17

rooted it could not easily be dismissed. The rifles required soldiers to bite open the greased coat, which served as a religious insult as consuming or touching beef or pork are religious restrictions. This fear was alarming to both groups and deepened their shared distrust of British authority. This moment has its valued significance as it challenged the assumption that religious differences would prevent cooperation. The Rebellion of 1857 showed that under certain circumstances, those differences could be set aside to unite people regardless of a religious barrier. However, British officials, particularly in regions like Punjab, used this situation as a learning opportunity. Punjab was known to be a region where many different religions were present which led to the British particularly prioritizing this region. Punjab's religious diversity made the region especially significant to colonial governance as Hindus, Muslims, and Sikhs lived in close proximity throughout the region. Punjab was increasingly viewed as a province where communal identities needed to be carefully categorized and managed in order to prevent another unified rebellion against colonial authority. These categorizations were working to reinforce distinctions rather than allowing common ground. Reflecting on Punjab's involvement within this Rebellion, independent researcher Hardeep Kaur asserts "The event of 1857 is certainly a watershed in Indian history as it resulted in blood- shed, and the British Indian Army, right from its inception, assumed a new shape. The British changed their overall policy towards Indian aristocracy and landlords to prevent the occurrence of such events in the future."[4] The rebels worked together towards a common cause that they believed in but the British used this as an opportunity to "prevent the occurrence of such events" to dominate their rule in the region. Religious separation was a slow yet effective strategy that was going to be implemented to maintain control. This would, over the course of generations, create widespread hate based on

[4] Kaur, Hardeep, "Revisiting Punjab's Role in the Revolt of 1857: Resistance, Repression and Exile", *Independent Researcher* https://giss.org/jsps_vol_32/03-kaur.pdf

religion that would allow Indians to fight one another instead of come together to fight the British. Over time, this shift contributed to the hardened religious identities that would play a major role in the violence of 1947.

The idea and process of conducting a census in a country has existed for centuries across the globe. India was no different, except with the caveat that this region was under British control. The first synchronous census, where all states reported at the same time, was conducted in 1881. However, this census was not only specific for being synchronous but also for being the first census with such dense categorization. The 1881 census separated by region, caste, gender, and religion alongside every other category one could think of. What people at the time may not have realized is how this categorization was to change lives for years to come. Especially in Punjab, these forms of categorization carried major political consequences as the region contained a population of Hindus, Muslims, and Sikhs living through the same districts and territories. To begin with caste separation, my mother's maiden name, or caste, is Saini while my father's is Bhatia. Both of these castes are included in the 1881 census alongside several others.



THE RELIGIONS OF THE PEOPLE. [Para. 248. Chap. IV.

Part II.—The Hindus of the Panjab.

the Amritsar Division another 13 per cent.; while the two frontier divisions together only include 3 per cent., and the Peshâwar Division less than 1 per cent.

248. Distribution of the Hindus according to Caste.—Abstract No. 51 below shows the composition by caste of the Hindu community in each division of the Province.

Abstract No. 51, *showing the* **Distribution of Male Hindus by Caste for Divisions.**

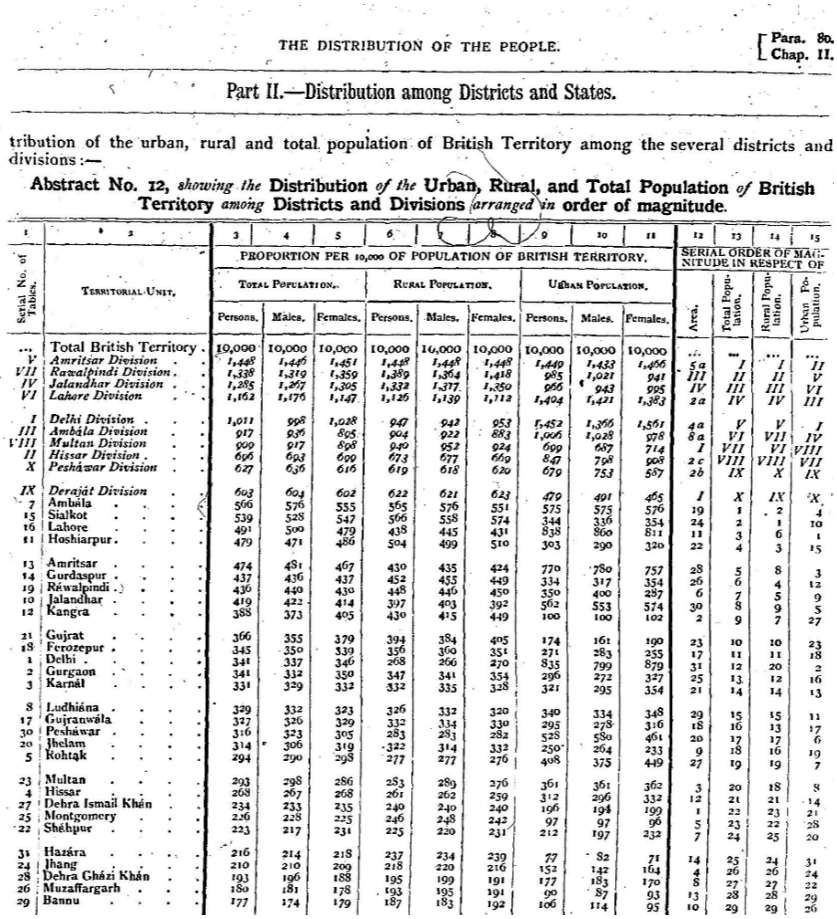
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	1
Caste.	Numbers of each Caste per 1,000 of Hindu Religion.													Caste.
	Delhi Division.	Hissar Division.	Ambala Division.	Jalandhar Division.	Amritsar Division.	Lahore Division.	Rawalpindi Division.	Multan Division.	Derajat Division.	Peshawar Division.	Total British Territory.	Total Native States.	Total Province.	
Number of Hindus per 1,000 of all religions.	721	750	577	651	338	223	111	178	116	58	378	549	407	Number of Hindus per 1,000 of all religions
Jat	186	356	214	124	139	109	22	5	5	23	168	155	166	Jat
Rajput	49	26	27	93	52	19	11	5	13	35	45	28	41	Rajput
Gujar	46	9	26	16	1	...	1	...	...	5	18	16	17	Gujar
Ror	25	...	5	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	6	...	4	Ror
Kamboh	6	...	10	2	3	12	...	44	...	...	6	4	6	Kamboh
Saini	1	...	61	32	14	...	...	...	...	...	18	5	15	Saini
Mâli	23	18	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	...	7	6	7	Mâli
Ahîr	59	26	2	...	1	6	5	2	...	10	16	28	19	Ahîr
Thakar	...	...	...	13	6	...	...	...	...	1	4	4	4	Thakar
Râthi	...	...	...	32	2	...	...	...	...	...	7	14	9	Râthi
Kanet	...	...	11	37	...	...	...	...	...	...	10	124	36	Kanet
Ghirath	...	...	1	92	6	...	...	...	...	...	21	16	16	Ghirath
Total Agricultural	386	435	357	441	224	146	39	56	18	74	326	385	340	Total Agricultural
Brâhman	120	97	91	137	128	106	148	47	64	116	113	124	116	Brâhman
Faqîr	24	22	20	10	13	16	14	11	9	6	17	20	17	Faqîr
Bhatia	...	...	...	...	6	2	22	8	28	4	3	1	2	Bhatia
Total Religious	144	119	111	147	147	124	184	66	101	126	133	145	135	Total Religious
Arora	...	7	...	1	32	134	249	643	773	252	70	28	60	Arora
Banya	75	86	47	3	30	28	9	2	2	11	40	53	43	Banya
Khatri	4	1	23	33	69	118	315	94	57	280	50	18	42	Khatri
Sûd	...	...	4	6	1	2	...	...	...	...	2	2	2	Sûd

5

This census report expanded for 573 pages with every categorization possible but the classification by caste becomes of interest. This section organizes several castes, more than what is shown, into numbers of each caste per 1000 people of the Hindu religion by geographical regions. For example, in the Amritsar, Punjab region there were 14 people of the Saini caste per 1000 people of the Hindu religion while there were only 6 per 1000 of the Bhatia caste. Indians were not only identified by caste, but also what type of caste which includes but is not limited to agricultural, religious, mercantile, and more. This is crucial because it depicts that the British administration did not only record existing social identities but actively fixed and standardized them into quantifiable categories that were rigid. The caste system previously existed in India but

[5] Report on the Census of Panjab. India Office Library. *Denzil Charles Jelf Ibbetson of Her Majesty's Bengal Civil Service.* Calcutta, India. February 17, 1881 (147). https://www.jstor.org/stable/saoa.crl.25057656?searchText=&searchUri=%2Faction%2FdoBasicSearch%3FQuery%3D1881%2Bcensus%2Bin%2BPunjab%2BIndia%26so%3Drel&ab_segments=0%2Fbasic_search_gsv2%2Fcontrol&searchKey=&refreqid=fastly-default%3A5ccc33201673b0c7a9522ca582c09a6d&initiator=recommender&seq=123

the British made it far more rigid in government rather than just socially as their means of control. By labeling communities under economic and social functions, such as "agricultural" and “mercantile”, the census reduced complex identities into simplified groups that could be separated and governed. Over time, such rigid distinctions could create more social boundaries and competition between groups, making unity more difficult which creates a political advantage for colonial rule. Caste was not the only grouping the British created as gender by territorial unit by type of population was also being measured.



THE DISTRIBUTION OF THE PEOPLE. [Para. 80, Chap. II.

Part II.—Distribution among Districts and States.

tribution of the urban, rural and total population of British Territory among the several districts and divisions :—

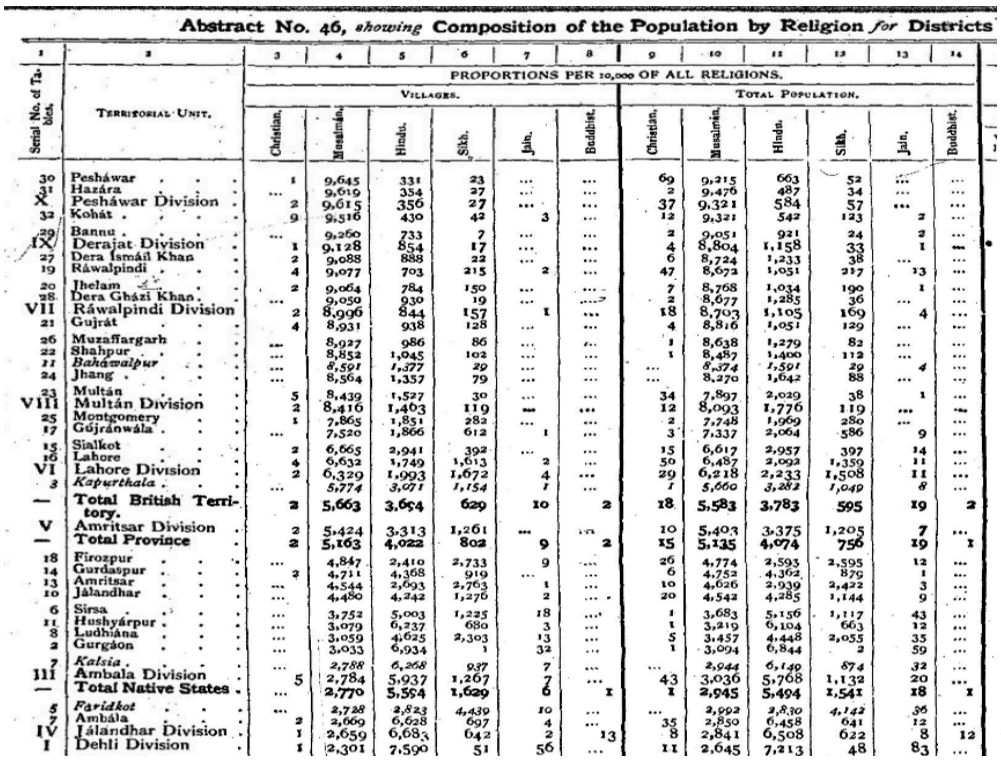
Abstract No. 12, *showing the* **Distribution** *of the* **Urban, Rural, and Total Population** *of* **British Territory** *among* **Districts and Divisions** *arranged in* **order of magnitude.**

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
Serial No. of Tables.	Territorial Unit.	Proportion per 10,000 of population of British Territory.									Serial order of magnitude in respect of			
		Total Population.			Rural Population.			Urban Population.			Area.	Total Population.	Rural Population.	Urban Population.
		Persons.	Males.	Females.	Persons.	Males.	Females.	Persons.	Males.	Females.				
...	Total British Territory	10,000	10,000	10,000	10,000	10,000	10,000	10,000	10,000	10,000	...	...	...	...
V	*Amritsar Division*	1,448	1,446	1,451	1,448	1,448	1,448	1,449	1,433	1,466	5a	I	I	II
VII	*Rawalpindi Division*	1,338	1,319	1,359	1,389	1,364	1,418	985	1,021	941	III	II	II	V
IV	*Jalandhar Division*	1,385	1,367	1,405	1,332	1,317	1,350	966	943	995	IV	III	III	VI
VI	*Lahore Division*	1,162	1,176	1,147	1,126	1,139	1,112	1,404	1,421	1,383	2a	IV	IV	III
I	*Delhi Division*	1,011	998	1,028	947	942	953	1,452	1,366	1,561	4a	V	V	I
III	*Ambála Division*	917	936	895	904	922	883	1,006	1,028	978	8a	VI	VII	IV
VIII	*Multan Division*	909	917	898	949	952	924	699	687	714	I	VII	VI	VIII
II	*Hissar Division*	696	693	699	673	677	669	847	798	908	2c	VIII	VIII	VII
X	*Peshawar Division*	627	636	616	619	618	620	679	753	587	2b	IX	X	IX
IX	*Derajat Division*	603	604	602	622	621	623	479	491	465	I	X	IX	X
7	Ambála	566	576	555	565	576	551	575	575	576	19	1	2	4
15	Sialkot	539	528	547	566	558	574	344	336	354	24	2	1	10
16	Lahore	491	500	479	438	445	431	838	860	811	11	3	6	1
11	Hoshiarpur	479	471	486	504	499	510	303	290	320	22	4	3	15
13	Amritsar	474	481	467	430	435	424	770	780	757	28	5	8	3
14	Gurdaspur	437	436	437	452	455	449	334	317	354	26	6	4	12
19	Rawalpindi	436	449	430	448	446	450	350	400	287	6	7	5	9
10	Jalandhar	419	422	414	397	403	392	562	553	574	30	8	9	5
12	Kangra	388	373	405	430	415	449	100	100	102	2	9	7	27
21	Gujrat	366	355	379	394	384	405	174	161	190	23	10	10	23
18	Ferozepur	345	350	339	356	360	351	271	283	255	17	11	11	18
1	Delhi	341	337	346	268	266	270	835	799	879	31	12	20	2
2	Gurgaon	341	332	350	347	341	354	296	272	327	25	13	12	16
3	Karnál	331	329	332	332	335	328	321	295	354	21	14	14	13
8	Ludhiána	329	332	323	326	332	320	340	334	348	29	15	15	11
17	Gujranwála	327	326	329	332	334	330	295	278	316	18	16	13	17
30	Peshawar	316	323	305	283	283	282	528	580	461	20	17	17	6
20	Jhelam	314	306	319	322	314	332	250	264	233	9	18	16	19
5	Rohtak	294	290	298	277	277	276	408	375	449	27	19	19	7
23	Multan	293	298	286	283	289	276	361	361	362	3	20	18	8
4	Hissar	268	267	268	261	262	259	312	296	332	12	21	21	14
27	Dehra Ismail Khán	234	233	235	240	240	240	196	194	199	1	22	23	21
25	Montgomery	226	228	225	246	248	242	97	97	96	5	23	22	28
22	Shéhpur	223	217	231	225	220	231	212	197	232	7	24	25	20
31	Hazára	216	214	218	237	234	239	77	82	71	14	25	24	31
24	Jhang	210	210	209	218	220	216	152	142	164	4	26	26	24
28	Dehra Gházi Khán	193	196	188	195	199	191	177	183	170	8	27	27	22
26	Muzaffargarh	180	181	178	193	195	191	90	87	93	13	28	28	29
29	Bannu	177	174	179	187	183	192	106	114	95	10	29	29	26

[6]

[6] Report on the Census of Panjab. India Office Library. *Denzil Charles Jelf Ibbetson of Her Majesty’s Bengal Civil Service*. Calcutta, India. February 17, 1881 (51). https://www.jstor.org/stable/saoa.crl.25057656?searchText=&searchUri=%2Faction%2FdoBasicSearch%3FQuery%3D1881%2Bcensus%2Bin%2BPunjab%2BIndia%26so%3Drel&ab_segments=0%2Fbasic_search_gsv2%2Fcontrol&searchKey=&refreqid=fastly-default%3A5ccc33201673b0c7a9522ca582c09a6d&initiator=recommender&seq=123

Gender was a prominent categorization in this census which can connect to my own lineage. My mother was born in Gurdaspur, Punjab but her grandparents, my great grandparents, were born in Lahore, Punjab. Both of these regions are specified with Gurdaspur having a 436:437 male to female ratio per 10,000 people in the region and Lahore having a 500:479 ratio. My father's side of the family is from Bannu, Punjab which is listed to have a 174:179 male to female ratio. This data depicts how the British census went beyond the simple population count and broke people down into highly specific, comparable units across regions. By quantifying differences such as gender ratios and organizing them geographically, the colonial administration created a system where communities could be measured and ultimately managed more efficiently. This emphasis on difference reinforced divisions within the population and made it easier for the British to rule, instead of fostering unity within diverse groups. Arguably, the most important categorization that was conducted by the British for not only this census but to set the tone for decades to come was religion.



Abstract No. 46, *showing* Composition of the Population by Religion *for* Districts

Serial No. of Table.	Territorial Unit.	Proportions per 10,000 of all religions. — Villages. Christian.	Villages. Musalmán.	Villages. Hindu.	Villages. Sikh.	Villages. Jain.	Villages. Buddhist.	Total Population. Christian.	Total Population. Musalmán.	Total Population. Hindu.	Total Population. Sikh.	Total Population. Jain.	Total Population. Buddhist.
30	Pesháwar	1	9,645	331	23	...	...	69	9,215	663	52	...	...
31	Hazára	...	9,619	354	27	...	...	2	9,476	487	34	...	...
X	Peshâwar Division	2	9,615	356	27	...	...	37	9,321	584	57	...	...
32	Kohát	9	9,516	430	42	3	...	12	9,321	542	123	2	...
29	Bannu	...	9,260	733	7	...	...	2	9,051	921	24	2	...
IX	Derajat Division	1	9,128	854	17	...	...	4	8,804	1,158	33	1	...
27	Dera Ismáil Khan	2	9,088	888	22	...	...	6	8,724	1,233	38	...	...
19	Ráwalpindi	4	9,077	703	215	2	...	47	8,692	1,051	217	13	...
20	Jhelam	2	9,064	784	150	...	...	7	8,768	1,034	190	1	...
28	Dera Ghází Khan	...	9,050	930	19	...	...	2	8,677	1,285	36	...	...
VII	Ráwalpindi Division	2	8,996	844	157	1	...	18	8,703	1,105	169	4	...
21	Gujrát	4	8,931	938	128	...	...	4	8,816	1,051	129	...	...
26	Muzaffargarh	...	8,927	986	86	...	...	1	8,638	1,279	82	...	...
22	Shahpur	...	8,852	1,045	102	...	...	1	8,487	1,400	112	...	...
11	*Bahâwalpur*	...	*8,591*	*1,377*	*29*	...	...	...	*8,374*	*1,591*	*29*	*4*	...
24	Jhang	...	8,564	1,357	79	...	...	...	8,270	1,642	88	...	...
23	Multán	5	8,439	1,527	30	...	...	34	7,897	2,029	38	1	...
VIII	Multán Division	2	8,416	1,403	119	...	...	12	8,093	1,776	119	...	...
25	Montgomery	1	7,865	1,851	282	...	...	2	7,748	1,969	280	...	...
17	Gújránwála	...	7,520	1,866	612	1	...	3	7,337	2,064	586	9	...
15	Sialkot	2	6,665	2,941	392	...	...	15	6,617	2,957	397	14	...
16	Lahore	4	6,632	1,749	1,613	2	...	50	6,487	2,092	1,359	11	...
VI	Lahore Division	2	6,329	1,993	1,672	4	...	29	6,218	2,233	1,508	11	...
3	*Kapurthala*	...	*5,774*	*3,071*	*1,154*	*1*	...	*1*	*5,660*	*3,282*	*1,049*	*8*	...
—	**Total British Territory.**	**2**	**5,663**	**3,654**	**629**	**10**	**2**	**18**	**5,583**	**3,783**	**595**	**19**	**2**
V	Amritsar Division	2	5,424	3,313	1,261	...	...	10	5,403	3,375	1,205	7	...
—	**Total Province**	**2**	**5,163**	**4,022**	**802**	**9**	**2**	**15**	**5,135**	**4,074**	**756**	**19**	**1**
18	Firozpur	...	4,847	2,410	2,733	9	...	26	4,774	2,593	2,595	12	...
14	Gurdaspur	2	4,711	4,368	919	...	...	6	4,752	4,362	879	1	...
13	Amritsar	...	4,544	2,693	2,763	1	...	10	4,626	2,939	2,422	3	...
10	Jálandhar	...	4,480	4,242	1,276	2	...	20	4,542	4,285	1,144	9	...
6	Sirsa	...	3,752	5,003	1,225	18	...	1	3,683	5,156	1,117	43	...
11	Hushyárpur	...	3,079	6,237	680	3	...	1	3,219	6,104	663	12	...
8	Ludhiána	...	3,059	4,625	2,303	13	...	5	3,457	4,448	2,055	35	...
2	Gurgáon	...	3,033	6,934	1	32	...	1	3,094	6,844	2	59	...
7	*Kalsia*	...	*2,788*	*6,268*	*887*	*7*	...	...	*3,044*	*6,148*	*874*	*32*	...
III	Ambala Division	5	2,784	5,937	1,267	7	...	43	3,036	5,768	1,132	20	...
—	**Total Native States**	...	**2,770**	**5,564**	**1,629**	**6**	**1**	**1**	**2,945**	**5,494**	**1,541**	**18**	**1**
5	*Faridkot*	...	*2,728*	*2,823*	*4,439*	*10*	...	...	*2,992*	*2,830*	*4,142*	*36*	...
7	Ambála	2	2,669	6,628	697	4	...	35	2,850	6,458	641	12	...
IV	Jálandhar Division	1	2,659	6,683	642	2	13	8	2,841	6,508	622	8	12
I	Dehli Division	1	2,301	7,590	51	56	...	11	2,645	7,213	48	83	...

[7]

This portion of the census covers the organization of people by religion and by district or region. For example, in Bannu, Punjab, Muslims were numbered 9,260 per 10,000 people while Hindus were 921 while in Lahore, Hindus numbered 1,749 while Muslims were 6,632 per 10,000 people. By quantifying these differences instead of conducting a simple population count, the British made religious communities both legible and comparable, reinforcing distinctions between groups that may have previously interacted more fluidly. This emphasis on measurable differences allowed officials to measure minority and majority populations, track demographic shifts, and treat communities differently which turned religion into the key to governance. These categorizations did not merely record social realities but they actively framed them as separate

[7] Report on the Census of Panjab. India Office Library. *Denzil Charles Jelf Ibbetson of Her Majesty's Bengal Civil Service*. Calcutta, India. February 17, 1881 (127). https://www.jstor.org/stable/saoa.crl.25057656?searchText=&searchUri=%2Faction%2FdoBasicSearch%3FQuery%3D1881%2Bcensus%2Bin%2BPunjab%2BIndia%26so%3Drel&ab_segments=0%2Fbasic_search_gsv2%2Fcontrol&searchKey=&refreqid=fastly-default%3A5ccc33201673b0c7a9522ca582c09a6d&initiator=recommender&seq=123

and distinct entities. In Punjab, where religious communities were heavily mixed geographically, these distinctions became increasingly important to political representation and social identity.

By creating this detailed religious map through an extensive 573-page census, the British laid the foundation for policies that emphasized division rather than unity. In Bannu and Lahore, Punjab, as well as elsewhere, these statistics could inform administrative decisions, allocate resources, and later on, influence political representation based on religion. In this way, the census itself became a tool of the 'divide and rule policy', the deliberate separation of communities to prevent unified opposition. This shaped how communities saw themselves and how they were treated during colonial rule. These divisions strengthened over time until chaos erupted in 1947 but until then, this statistical groundwork directly influenced later measures of communal representation, contributing to the formation of the All-India Muslim League where religious identity became a basis for political unity.

As these religious divisions became more distinct through the work of the census, they did not remain confined to administrative records but rather began to influence how communities viewed themselves within the political system. By the early twentieth century, this growing awareness led to the formation of the All-India Muslim League, a political ground that called for a separate Muslim nation while protecting the rights of their own. The emergence of such organizations reflects a shift in which religion was no longer a social or cultural identity but rather a basis for political organization and advocacy. This shift carried particular significance in Punjab because no single religious community completely dominated the province. Muslims formed the largest population, while substantial Hindu and Sikh communities feared political marginalization under a Muslim-majority governance. British officials themselves recognized the challenges that arose from this shift. As they attempted to implement systems of representation,

they acknowledged that "The most difficult of the problems to be faced was the representation of Muhammadans, who claimed to be represented as a separate class or community."[8] The statement highlights how Muslims were being increasingly understood, both by their own community and by colonial authorities as a distinct political group requiring specific consideration. Rather than encouraging a unified political system, this recognition reinforced the idea that religious communities should be treated separately within the government and its powers.

In response to these emerging demands, the British structured political representation in ways that further emphasized division. The Indian Councils Act of 1909, also known as the Minto-Morley Reforms "expanded the size of India's imperial and local legislative councils and increased Indian participation in governance"[9], which ultimately meant that Indians were now allowed to participate more in government rather than solely the British. However, the British were building upon more strategic religious division so giving power to Indians was not as adequate as it seemed. This Act granted the Governor-General the authority to "make regulations regulations, as to the conditions under which and manner in which persons resident in India may be nominated or elected as members of the Legislative Councils"[10], placing control over political participation firmly in colonial hands. This power allowed for British to design electoral systems that accounts for what they described as "special provision" for "smaller classes and minor interests"[11], which effectively organized political representation around distinct social and

---

[8] Ilbert, Sir Courtenay, "The Government of India Supplementary Chapter - Indian Councils Act 1909", Oxford at the Clarendon Press, 1910, pg.14
https://dspace.gipe.ac.in/xmlui/bitstream/handle/10973/39479/GIPE-063131.pdf?sequence=3&isAllowed=y

[9] "1909 Act of Government of India or Minto-Morley Reforms"
https://www.scribd.com/document/692836209/1909-ACT-0F-GOVERNMENT-OF-INDIA

[10] "Indian Councils Act, 1909", Chapter 4, page 3
https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukpga/Edw7/9/4/pdfs/ukpga_19090004_en.pdf

[11] Ilbert, Sir Courtenay, "Indian Councils Act, 1909", Cambridge University Press, no.2 (1911): pg.8
https://www.jstor.org/stable/752520?seq=8

religious groups. Through these measures, religious identity became embedded within the structure of the government itself. What had initially been a method of classification through the census evolved into a system in which communities not only saw themselves as separate, but were also politically represented as such. This transformation marked a critical step in the development of communal divisions, as competition for political power increasingly took place along religious lines rather than through a shared national identity.

Over time, these institutionalized divisions did not remain limited to representation within colonial governance. These divisions began to shape broader political movements and ideologies as leaders and communities increasingly associated themselves in opposition to one another along religious lines. Ultimately, this opposition exponentially increased that resulted in the violent Partition of 1947. Punjab became the center of the violence because the region itself was separated between India and Pakistan despite its heavily mixed religious population. Cities, villages, and even families throughout Punjab were suddenly separated by borders created within only a matter of weeks, including my own lineage. The Partition of India occurred due to rising conflicts between the League's rising demands for a separate Muslim nation and with the heightened desire of the British to leave amidst all the communal violence. Lord Mountbatten, the last viceroy, or high-ranking colonial officer under the British rule, of India, was responsible for transferring the power from the British to newly made India. He states in an address "But there can be no question of coercing any large areas in which one community has a majority to live against their will under a Government in which another community has a majority—and the only alternative to coercion is partition."[12]. Mountbatten recognized the rising wishes to separate by religion, ultimately transferring power over a very short period of time and pulling the British

[12] Mountbatten, Louis, "Broadcast by Viceroy", Radio Broadcast on June 4th, 1947, https://www.nationalarchives.gov.uk/education/resources/indian-independence/mountbatten-radio-broadcast/

Crown out of India. Mountbatten was known to significantly accelerate the Partition plan as he spent roughly five months on it after arriving in India. He pushed the independence date to August 15, 1947 which was nearly a year earlier than the original June 1948 target to expedite the British withdrawal. This rushed timeline was in part that the British felt a faster exit was necessary to prevent a civil war but it was almost strategic to do so. The British Empire has ruled all over the globe and yet historically has left regions in a point of chaos. What this accomplishes is the British conserved most of their power to themselves when they ruled and once all that power is given to a region that may not know how to handle it, the question of returning to its original rule rises up. Tensions were at their highest and the British did not want to be blamed for all the divisions they had created during their 90 years of rule. This urgency also meant that Partition was a rapid administrative decision and not a fully planned political transition, which increased the risk of long-standing communal tensions erupting immediately after the removal of authority. Another drawback of the rushed departure was the drawing of the Radcliffe Line, the border between India and Pakistan. Sir Cyril Radcliffe, who had never previously been to India, was only given weeks to divide Punjab and other states despite their heavily mixed population of Hindus, Muslims, and Sikhs. The borders were not even officially announced until after independence had already taken effect, creating confusion and panic amongst millions of people migrating across the new borders. The speed of withdrawal did not just fail to prevent violence, but shaped the conditions in which violence could spread rapidly and uncontrollably across Punjab. This ultimately turned political separation into immediate mass displacement and conflict on an unprecedented scale.

As the British departed India, leaving the region in a sense of chaos, brutal killing and massacres based on religion began to rise to unprecedented levels. The 1947 train massacres

were a series of trains attacked while refugees attempted to cross the newly created borders between India and Pakistan. Hindus and Sikhs were told to live in India and Muslims to live in Pakistan so based on religion, millions of people were travelling across borders. Hindus and Sikhs were attacking trains full of Muslims, such as the 1947 Amritsar Train Massacre, while Muslims were attacking Hindus and Sikhs, such as the Kamoke Train Massacre before these trains would make it past border lines. My father's side of the family were fortunate enough to take the train right after the Kamoke, which may have just saved the rest of the lineage. What happened at Kamoke, Amritsar, and several other regions would ultimately write history.

The violence that occurred across refugee trains in Punjab demonstrates just how deeply religious identity had become tied to survival and political belonging by 1947. Trains meant to transport refugees to safety suddenly became sites of massacre where passengers were targeted solely because of whether they were Hindu, Muslim, or Sikh. One report for *The Advertiser* describes what occurred on the Amritsar train as it says "After arrival at Amritsar on Monday evening the train pulled up a short distance from the platform. A crowd of Sikhs, armed with rifles, swords, and spears, opened fire from both sides of the track."[13] The article later explains "The Sikhs then closed in and swept through the train killing men, women and children by sword and spear." The attack was highly organized rather than spontaneous, showing how violence had become structured around identity rather than isolated incidents of conflict. These attacks were not the result of just the British declaring their departure from India but rather divisions built over the span of ninety years. Another significant aspect of these massacres was the collapse of authority on the ground. The same report explains that the British officer commanding the train's defence ordered the escorts to fire back, however "they fired over the heads of the attackers." By

[13] "3,000 Dead in Indian Train Massacre". *The Advertiser,* September 26, 1947. https://trove.nla.gov.au/newspaper/article/36001501

this point, British control no longer functioned in practice, even if it still existed on paper. What mattered in these moments was not law or command, but which group people identified with and were willing to defend. After decades of colonial policies that categorized and politically separated communities through census classification and communal representation, those divisions had hardened to the point where even colonial authority could no longer override them.

Similar violence was occurring during the Kamoke massacre, the one my father's family just survived, where "Several thousand Moslems attacked a Sikh and Hindu refugee train."[14] Reports throughout September, 1947 reveal how widespread these attacks had become, with one military spokesman admitting that "All seven trains which have left Lahore since September 18 have been attacked."[15] This depicts that the train massacres were not isolated events but part of a wider pattern across Punjab, where migration itself became dangerous and often fatal. Refugee trains were no longer a means of transportation but rather moving boundaries of the Partition where identity determined life or death even before the border was crossed.

The testimonies from survivors further reveal the human consequences of this violence. Statements collected by the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) describe families being slaughtered while attempting to flee while women being abducted, raped, and forced into marriage during migration. A survivor, Ram Piari, describes "I was forced to accompany a Muslim whose name I do not know. Later at the asking of Labhu, a tongawala of Baghbanpura, I was taken over by him. Against my consent and at the point of dagger I was subjected to rape by Labhu … After 7-8 days this Labhu against my wishes performed Nikah

[14] "Another Indian Train Massacre". *Daily News,* September 26, 1947. https://trove.nla.gov.au/newspaper/article/84013436
[15] "India's Worst Train Massacre". *Northern Advocate,* September 24, 1947. https://paperspast.natlib.govt.nz/newspapers/NA19470925.2.61#image-tab

ceremony with me and used me as a wife."[16] This woman was brutally raped and forced into marriage at the threat of death entirely against her will which serves as just one example of how the violence of Parition had truly escalated as a result of religious division. These accounts come together to show how Partition violence extended beyond political conflict and became deeply personal, affecting families and entire communities in ways that could not be reversed.

Ultimately, the violence that erupted in 1947 was not simply the result of ancient hatred between Hindu and Muslims. Rather, it was the culmination of decades of British colonial policies that institutionalized religious division through rigid classification, biased representation, and political separation. Beginning after the Rebellion of 1857, British governance increasingly relied on categorizing population through religion and caste in order to maintain control. Over time, these categories became the main way communities understood each other and political identity itself. By the time of the Partition, those divisions were no longer solely administrative but were social and political in ways that shaped how people acted under mass pressure. The train massacres of the Partition therefore were not random means of violence, but the final breaking point of a system that had turned identity into something rigid, political, and competitive.

The effects of this system did not end in 1947. The displacement, fear, and distrust produced during the ninety-year period leading up to 1947 continued to shape relations between India and Pakistan but also with Hindus, Muslims, and Sikhs long after independence. Though caste systems have diminished over time, the separation and division amongst religious groups

---

[16] Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC), *Muslim League Attack on Sikhs and Hindus in the Punjab 1947* (Allahabad Law Journal Press), 475-476, 1950 https://dn790007.ca.archive.org/0/items/muslim-league-attack-on-sikhs-and-hindus-in-the-punjab-1947-gurbachan-singh-talib-ram-swarup/Muslim%20League%20Attack%20on%20Sikhs%20and%20Hindus%20in%20the%20Punjab%201947.pdf

still prominently exists on both sides of the borders. Discussions over nationalism, citizenship, and religious identity in South Asia are still today reflected by many of the boundaries and tensions hardened under colonial rule. Thus, Partition not only signals the end of British India, but also the start of a long-lasting legacy where political identity is still shaped by the divisions first reinforced under colonial rule. Generations across Punjab watched violence through a lens of religious division and fear, much like the young girl on the refugee train in the opening image. Decades of colonial policies had created a political rigidity around identity that by 1947, for many across Punjab, all they could see was red.

Bibliography

Primary:

"3,000 Dead in Indian Train Massacre". *The Advertiser,* September 26, 1947. https://trove.nla.gov.au/newspaper/article/36001501

"Another Indian Train Massacre". *Daily News,* September 26, 1947. https://trove.nla.gov.au/newspaper/article/84013436

Crawshay, Geo. "The Immediate Cause of The Indian Mutiny". Lecture at the Mechanic's Institution, Gateshead. London, England. November 4th, 1857. https://www.jstor.org/stable/60229514?searchText=indian+rebellion+of+1857&searchUri=%2Faction%2FdoBasicSearch%3FQuery%3Dindian%2Brebellion%2Bof%2B1857%26so%3Drel%26sd%3D1857%26ed%3D1860&ab_segments=0%2Fbasic_search_gsv2%2Fcontrol&refreqid=fastly-default%3Ac6e0f6a12c3e03b8a922e93729d67b30&seq=17

Hashmi, Salima, "Oral history with Salima Hashmi, 2016 January 18", Stanford University Libraries, 2016 https://exhibits.stanford.edu/1947-partition/browse/interviews

Report on the Census of Panjab. India Office Library. *Denzil Charles Jelf Ibbetson of Her Majesty's Bengal Civil Service.* Calcutta, India. February 17, 1881 (51, 127, 147). https://www.jstor.org/stable/saoa.crl.25057656?searchText=&searchUri=%2Faction%2FdoBasicSearch%3FQuery%3D1881%2Bcensus%2Bin%2BPunjab%2BIndia%26so%3Drel&ab_segments=0%2Fbasic_search_gsv2%2Fcontrol&searchKey=&refreqid=fastly-default%3A5ccc33201673b0c7a9522ca582c09a6d&initiator=recommender&seq=123

Ilbert, Sir Courtenay, "Indian Councils Act, 1909", Cambridge University Press, no.2 (1911): pg.8 https://www.jstor.org/stable/752520?seq=8

Ilbert, Sir Courtenay, "The Government of India Supplementary Chapter - Indian Councils Act 1909", Oxford at the Clarendon Press, 1910, pg.14 https://dspace.gipe.ac.in/xmlui/bitstream/handle/10973/39479/GIPE-063131.pdf?sequence=3&isAllowed=y

"Indian Councils Act, 1909", Chapter 4, page 3 https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukpga/Edw7/9/4/pdfs/ukpga_19090004_en.pdf

"India's Worst Train Massacre". *Northern Advocate,* September 24, 1947. https://paperspast.natlib.govt.nz/newspapers/NA19470925.2.61#image-tab

Mountbatten, Louis, "Broadcast by Viceroy", Radio Broadcast on June 4th, 1947, https://www.nationalarchives.gov.uk/education/resources/indian-independence/mountbatten-radio-broadcast/

Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC), *Muslim League Attack on Sikhs and Hindus in the Punjab 1947* (Allahabad Law Journal Press), 475-476, 1950 https://dn790007.ca.archive.org/0/items/muslim-league-attack-on-sikhs-and-hindus-in-the-punjab-1947-gurbachan-singh-talib-ram-swarup/Muslim%20League%20Attack%20on%20Sikhs%20and%20Hindus%20in%20the%20Punjab%201947.pdf

Secondary:

"1909 Act of Government of India or Minto-Morley Reforms" https://www.scribd.com/document/692836209/1909-ACT-0F-GOVERNMENT-OF-INDIA

Kaur, Hardeep, "Revisiting Punjab's Role in the Revolt of 1857: Resistance, Repression and Exile", *Independent Researcher* https://giss.org/jsps_vol_32/03-kaur.pdf

Robb, Peter, "On the Rebellion of 1857: A Brief History of an Idea", *Economic and Political Weekly,* Vol.42 No.19 (May 2007). https://www.jstor.org/stable/4419572?searchText=indian+rebellion+of+1857&searchUri=%2Faction%2FdoBasicSearch%3FQuery%3Dindian%2Brebellion%2Bof%2B1857%26so%3Drel&ab_segments=0%2Fbasic_search_gsv2%2Fcontrol&refreqid=fastly-default%3Af5f2bd278e0c595c2c95337f9c93615f&seq=2